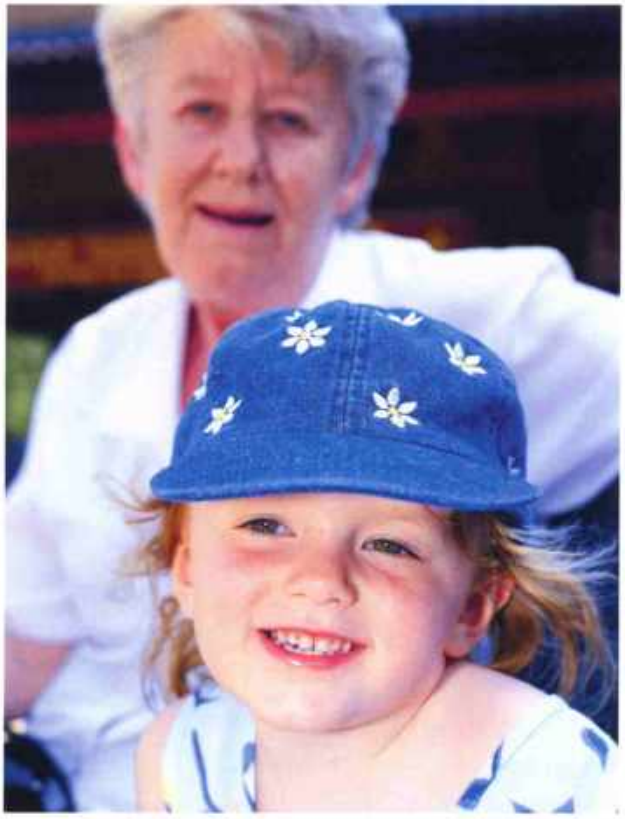
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YOUR COMMUNITY MAGAZINE
ISSUE 11
DECEMBER 05

KEEPING WARM THIS WINTER



With this winter expected to be the coldest in a decade, vulnerable people such as the elderly are at much greater risk of becoming seriously ill. Many pensioners are afraid to keep their homes warm throughout the winter months as they worry about the cost of fuel and electricity bills. However, help is at hand. **Marie Dunster** takes a look at what benefits and help are available and how we can all take action to stay warm this winter.

One of the main causes of winter deaths among the elderly is a cold, damp home. Currently, Help the Aged estimate that over 1.4 million households with someone over 65 living there are without proper heating or insulation. That means that nearly 5% of all households in Britain will not be enjoying a cosy festive season this year. As the weather gets colder, heating costs become a real concern for many people. This winter however, there are a number of payments that are being made available to elderly and vulnerable people. The extra money these payments provide will help towards the cost of keeping warm and safe over the coming months.

NEWS NOTES
What's new at Waterways

ONE TO ONE
Making a difference

CHRISTMAS CRACKER
Join the party

GALLIONS HOUSING ASSOCIATION

COLD WEATHER PAYMENTS

A Winter Fuel Payment of at least £200 is due to go to households that include someone who was aged 60 or over on 25th September 2005 and receives a state pension. You usually do not have to apply for this allowance, as it will normally be paid automatically to those who qualify before the end of the year. It is a good way to help pay larger fuel bills and it can provide real peace of mind to many elderly residents. Payments should be made between mid November and Christmas. If you have not received your payment by then it may mean that you are one of the few people who do not qualify automatically and have to make a claim. If you are in this position you should contact the Winter Fuel Payments Helpline on 08459 151515

As well as the Winter Fuel Payments, a number of age-related payments may also be paid to households that include a pensioner. Again, eligible pensioners must be the correct age or over on 25th September 2005 to qualify for these additional payments. Households including someone aged 65 or over may receive an extra payment of up to £200 to help with Council Tax bills. Households including someone aged 70 or over may receive £50 to help with living expenses, a payment that rises to £100 if the person is aged 80 or over.

Cold Weather Payments are paid automatically when the temperature drops to 0°C or below for a seven-day period. People who receive Income Support or income-based Jobseeker's Allowance are entitled to Cold Weather Payments.



FIND OUT MORE

All of these payments can make a real difference – in some cases the difference between life and death. If it is a harsh winter then do make sure that your elderly friends, relatives and neighbours are taking good care of themselves. Let them know that help is available and try and check on them regularly.

There is a helpline available if you would like more information about winter payments.

The Winter Fuel Payments Helpline is open from Monday to Friday from 8.30am to 4.30pm, just ring 08459 151515 and have your National Insurance number to hand.

TOP TIPS FOR STAYING WARM THIS WINTER

- Make sure your central heating works.
- Use draft excluders on doors, letter boxes, and keyholes.
- Wear several thin layers of clothing rather than one thick layer.
- Eat at least one hot meal a day.
- Sip hot drinks regularly throughout the day and before bedtime.

GETTING THE BEST PRICE FOR FUEL

You may be able to reduce your fuel costs by changing your fuel provider. Many fuel companies now operate fuel schemes that can save you money if you buy both gas and electricity from that supplier. If you need information or advice about changing to a new fuel supplier, you can telephone **Energywatch on 08459 060708**. Their helpline will put you through to your local office that can provide general information and advice about a change of fuel supplier.

THE WARM FRONT SCHEME

The best way to reduce the amount of fuel you use for heating is to make sure your home is well insulated. Good insulation will keep the heat in and drafts and colds out. A lot of heat escapes through doors, windows and walls. There are a number of cheap and easy measures that can make your home dryer and warmer.

Fixing a brush or seal to outer doors will help stop draughts coming in while lagging hot water cylinders and pipes will help keep heat in. Many independent fuel companies and local authorities operate grants and schemes as well as providing energy efficiency advice. In England you are eligible for a Warm Front grant if you:

- have children under 16 and are getting Child Benefit or with a maternity certificate, and getting one of more of the following - Income Support, Housing Benefit, Council Tax Benefit, income-based Jobseeker's Allowance, or Pension Credit

- are getting one or more of the following - Attendance Allowance, Disability Living Allowance, Industrial Injuries Disablement Benefit (which includes Constant Attendance Allowance), or War Disablement Pension (which must include the mobility or Constant Attendance Allowance)

- are getting one or more of the following - Income Support,Housing Benefit or Council Tax Benefit, when they include a disability premium

- are 60 or over, and getting Income Support, Council Tax Benefit, Housing Benefit, income-based Jobseeker's Allowance, or Pension Credit.

For more information about energy efficiency
PLEASE CALL FREEPHONE 0800 512 012

ISSUE #11
editorial

It has been a year since Thamesview was launched and in that time we have worked hard to deliver a magazine that meets the needs of all Gallions' residents. Over the months we have covered the summer festival and fun days, Thamesmead in Bloom as well as raising awareness about many key environmental issues. Our news pages have provided important information about anti-social behaviour, community projects and updates on developments in Tavy Bridge. Thamesview is a magazine for and about Gallions residents and we have enjoyed meeting you and listening to your stories. Thankyou to everyone who has contributed to the magazine.

The Thamesview Team would like to wish its readers lots of festive cheer and a Happy New Year!

1 **Winter Warmer**
chill out in the cold weather

4 **Waste not, want not**
Christmas recycling

6 **News Notes**
Keeping up to date

7 **One to One**
Making a difference

8 **Christmas Cracker**
Festive fun and food

ਜੇ ਅੰਗਰੇਜ਼ੀ ਤੁਹਾਡੀ ਪਹਿਲੀ ਭਾਸ਼ਾ ਨਹੀਂ, ਅਤੇ ਤੁਸੀਂ ਇਸ ਦਸਤਾਵੇਜ਼ ਦਾ ਤਰਜਮਾ ਚਾਹੁੰਦੇ ਹੋ, ਤਾਂ ਕਿਰਪਾ ਕਰਕੇ ਆਪਣੀ ਚੁਣੀ ਹੋਈ ਭਾਸ਼ਾ ਦੇ ਨਾ ਦੇ ਨੇੜੇ ਵਾਲੇ ਖ਼ਾਨੇ ਵਿਚ ਸਹੀ ਦਾ ਨਿਸ਼ਾਨ ਲਾ ਕੇ, ਅਤੇ ਦੱਸੀ ਹੋਈ ਥਾਂ 'ਤੇ ਆਪਣਾ ਨਾ ਅਤੇ ਪਤਾ ਲਿਖ ਕੇ ਇਹ ਫ਼ਾਰਮ ਕਿਸੇ ਲਿਫ਼ਾਫ਼ੇ ਵਿਚ ਪਾ ਕੇ ਹੇਠ ਲਿਖੇ ਪਤੇ 'ਤੇ ਭੇਜ ਦਿਓ।

如果英語不是您的母語，您希望將該文件翻譯出來的話，請在您選擇的語言旁邊打勾。請在所示之處填上您的姓名和地址，併用信封將本表格寄到下列地址。

Nếu Anh ngữ không phải là ngôn ngữ chính, Quý vị muốn dịch tài liệu này, xin vui lòng đánh dấu vào ô kế bên ngôn ngữ Quý vị chọn, ghi tên và địa chỉ vào nơi chỉ dẫn và gởi mẫu vào phòng bì theo địa chỉ dưới đây.

December 05

PUNJABI ☐ **CHINESE** ☐ **VIETNAMESE** ☐
(please tick one)

Name: _____

Address: _____

_____

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Return to: Joy McKee, Translation Requests, Gallions Housing Association, Harrow Manor Way, London SE2 9XH

DON'T LET CHRISTMAS GO TO WASTE



Recycle Reclaim & Re-use

While Christmas is a time of giving and sharing, it is also a time of enormous waste. Despite the fact that half the waste could easily be recycled or put on a compost heap, nearly 80% of it will end up in the dustbin or littering the streets. Many environmental agencies are today calling on people across the country to make a greater effort to recycle as much as they possibly can during the festive season.

The amount of waste created over Christmas is the same as 400,000 double decker buses parked in a line and stretching all the way from London to New York! Also, there will be enough wrapping paper alone to gift-wrap the whole island of Guernsey. These staggering statistics are just some examples given by the Department of Environment, Food and Rural Affairs to highlight the huge problem of festive waste. Environment Minister Elliot Morley says:

"Over 24 million glass jars of mincemeat, pickles and cranberry sauce will be consumed over Christmas. If these were recycled, it would save enough energy to boil water for 60 million cups of tea."

A whole range of household rubbish such as pizza boxes, crisp packets, juice cartons, tins and bottles and even the foil the turkey was cooked in can all be taken to the recycling bins. Like most other supermarkets, Morrisons has a large recycling bin in the car park.

Turning rubbish into rewards

There are many charities across the country turning waste into valuable funds for a whole range of good causes. Here are just some of this year's charitable appeals and environmental campaigns.

* Last year the Woodland Trust recycled 58 million cards and this year bins will again be in all WH Smith High Street stores and all Tesco Extra and Superstores throughout January 2006. The Woodland Trust aims to plant 12 million trees over the next five years.

* Oxfam is turning unwanted mobile phones and their accessories into money to support work with people all over the world. You can support their *'bring bring'* campaign by handing your old phones into any Oxfam shop. If you have collected more than 10 old phones **please call 0870 752 0999** and a courier will be arranged to collect them.

* The children's television programme Blue Peter is running a Treasure Trail Appeal to raise money for children. By collecting old coins left over from holidays and mobile phones they aim to raise enough funds to help Childline answer 5,000 more calls. Branches of Barclays Bank have special treasure trail boxes to collect recyclable goods.

You can find out more about recycling and what services are available by calling Recycle for London on

0845 3 313131

Let's make this Christmas really sparkle

Not only does recycling waste help raise funds and protect the environment, it also helps keep Thamesmead's streets and landings clear of rubbish. Every Christmas huge amounts of rubbish are simply left lying in and around Thamesmead. Wrapping paper, cardboard boxes, bin liners full of waste and even televisions and fridges are regularly collected from around the area. This causes a lot of extra work for Team Gallions and a lot of distress to those residents who want their neighbourhood to look clean and tidy when visitors arrive over the holidays.

Team Gallions has outlined a few small steps you can take that will make a big difference this Christmas.

- ✶ USE THE RUBBISH CHUTE
- ✶ PUT RUBBISH IN THE DUSTBIN
- ✶ USE THE COUNCIL RECYCLING BINS
- ✶ TAKE RUBBISH TO THE TIP

TEAM GALLIONS RUBBISH AMNESTY WILL BE RUNNING THE SECOND WEEK OF JANUARY.

PLEASE PHONE 0800 83 84 81 TO MAKE AN APPOINTMENT.

TIP OPENING TIMES

NATHAN WAY

OPEN

Monday – Friday	8am – 6.30pm
Saturday	8am – 4.30pm
Sunday	9am – 4.00pm

CLOSED

Christmas Day
Boxing Day
New Year's Day

THAMES ROAD

OPEN

Monday – Sunday	7.30am – 4.00pm
Tues 27th Dec.	10am –2.00pm
Wed 28th – Sat 31st Dec	7.30am – 4.00pm
New Years Day	10am – 2.00pm
Mon 2nd Jan	10am –2.00pm

CLOSED

Christmas Day
Boxing Day

Bring your Christmas tree to Harrow Manor Way and Team Gallions will chip it down ready for re-planting or recyling.

FOR QUERIES ABOUT COUNCIL RUBBISH COLLECTION OVER THE HOLIDAYS CALL

BEXLEY 0208 303 7777, OPTION 1

GREENWICH 0208 921 4661





News Notes



TAKING TIME TO REMEMBER

This year, for the first time ever, the new memorial gardens at Teeswater Court were home to a Remembrance Sunday service. The gardens are a result of a partnership between the Royal British Legion, Team Gallions, Tilfen Land, and Willow Funeral Services. Each partner played a key role, with Team Gallions installing the flag pole and benches. A special thanks goes out to all the residents and the Garden Committee at Teeswater Court for their kind help and consideration. The service will now become an annual event to ensure the memories of those lost in conflicts can be remembered in the community.

BABIES GALORE!

It is sure to be an extra happy Christmas this year at Waterways nursery as staff and children celebrate the opening of their baby unit. The nursery, which started up in Thamesmead nearly 20 years ago, was determined to save itself from closure through lack of funds. By opening a baby unit that can care for babies from the age of 12 weeks, Waterways was able to secure enough funds to keep its doors open. There was a huge amount of support from the local community with a number of people donating their services and goods free of charge. The managers and staff were delighted at the response to their plea for help. Waterways Manager said **"We would like to say a big thank you to all the people who gave their time. Without their support we would simply not have been able to carry on."** Waterways now cares for nearly 44 pre-schoolers as well as 6 young babies. For more information please contact the manager on 0208 311 5491.



GALLIONS REVENUE TEAM HAS BEEN RESTRUCTURED AND IS NOW KNOWN AS THE CREDIT CONTROL TEAM. RESIDENTS WITH REVENUE QUERIES SHOULD NOW ASK TO SPEAK TO THE CREDIT CONTROL TEAM.



This winter many of Thamesmead's lakes and canals may freeze over.
Please make your children aware of the dangers and do not let them play on or around any frozen lakes, canals or waterways.

one to one

Making a difference



Having worked his way up from the shop floor of a box-making firm to management, Phil Briggs is a man not afraid to take up a challenge. However, when he joined Gallions as a Neighbourhood Warden seven months ago, he was absolutely terrified of getting it all wrong. Today, he is happier than he has ever been in any job.

Phil has lived in Thamesmead for more than 25 years and in that time he has organised more street parties than he cares to remember. For him Thamesmead has always been a friendly and supportive community where his family grew up. So when he heard that Gallions were looking for a new neighbourhood warden he jumped at the chance.

"Thamesmead has been good to me and I really wanted to give something back to the community. I am a 'people person' and this seemed like a great opportunity."

What struck Phil immediately was the great team he got to work with. While every warden brought something different to the table all were equally committed to making a real difference to the community. Often having to think on their feet and work solely by instinct, Phil's first week as a warden was something of a baptism of fire.

"We found ourselves in a very difficult situation where we all had to pull together and make important decisions quickly. While it was very frightening it was great to be part of such a strong team. Many thought that I would quit after the first week – but I was hooked!"

Choices and changes

Phil firmly believes that one way to steer children away from anti-social behaviour is to offer them choices – to introduce different things to keep them busy and out of trouble. Recently the wardens have been working closely with Heronsgate School in Broadwaters. By listening to the children and learning about the real issues that concern them, the wardens are introducing projects that will benefit the whole of Thamesmead.

"We want the young people of Thamesmead to become more actively involved in their community. Whether it's joining a club, playing sport or helping with the upkeep of the environment, our message is that everyone has something positive to contribute."

The wardens have recently launched the 'Pet Project', a scheme designed by Loretta and delivered by Phil and Fliss. Exploring how to care for different types of pets and animals, it is an ideal way to teach young people about the environment, wildlife and ecological issues. It is educational projects like this that are sparking a real interest in the children.

Before Phil became a warden he had little idea of what the job involved. Today, he is in no doubt of his role and responsibilities to the community. It is hard to define exactly what makes a good warden but for Phil a key ingredient is respect – both showing and earning it. Early next year, there will be a total of 8 wardens in and around Thamesmead. When the new wardens are recruited Phil will be the first to help them overcome any nerves they may have.

"I was terrified but I can honestly say that this is the most rewarding, and challenging, job I have ever done. I love it."



Cracker of a Christmas Party at The Atrium

Teeswater Court, Mangold Way, Thamesmead

Wednesday 21st December 2pm - 5.30pm

Festive fun, food and seasonal songs for the over 60's

FREE

To book your place please call The Thamesview Team on

0208 320 3414 **or see the Neighbourhood Wardens**

Limited transport and Warden escorts are available so please ask for details

Contact us

Gallions Housing Association
Harrow Manor Way
London
SE2 9XH

For all enquiries please contact the
Customer Response Centre
0800 83 84 81
It's a freephone number that you can use to book services, repairs or for any other enquiries.

GALLIONS HOUSING ASSOCIATION

neighbourhood forums

INFORMATION AND DISCUSSION ABOUT LIFE IN YOUR COMMUNITY

We are making some big changes to improve our neighbourhood forums - changes that we hope will benefit the whole of Thamesmead.

Next year, our neighbourhood forums will offer a wide range of services to meet the many different needs of our residents. Our exciting new approach to resident involvement sees a whole new flexible format.

- an open surgery to come along and talk to your housing co-ordinator
- a guest speaker to talk about the issues that affect you and your community
- discussion sessions with Gallions staff on hand to answer your questions
- a chance to meet residents and neighbours from across Thamesmead

Our neighbourhood forums will be looking at issues such as:

anti-social behaviour • neighbourhood wardens • planned maintenance and any other subjects that you would like to see on the agenda.

Dates and venues for neighbourhood forums in your area will be sent to you in January 2006 when we will also be announcing details of the year's estate walkabouts.

Your input will help build a brighter Thamesmead and we are looking forward to working together. For more information please call our Resident Involvement Team.

0800 838481

Gallions
HOUSING ASSOCIATION